

International Political Economy

Sample Syllabus

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Upper-division undergraduate seminar | 3 credits | 15-week semester

About this document. This is a sample syllabus prepared for teaching portfolio purposes. It presents my own course design: the sequencing, the assessment architecture, the assignment prompts, and the reading selection. Calendar dates, meeting times, course numbers, learning-management-system references, and institution-specific administrative policies have been removed, and weeks are numbered rather than dated so that the design can be read independently of any particular academic calendar. A course actually offered would carry the host institution's required policy statements.

Course Description

This seminar investigates the dynamic interaction between international politics and global economics. It examines how domestic political institutions, organized interests, and international rules govern cross-border flows of trade, investment, money, and financial capital.

The course builds mastery of the field's core theories, analytical models, and structural frameworks, including Open Economy Politics, the factor and sector models of trade preferences, strategic trade theory, and the impossible trinity. Students then apply those theoretical architectures directly to seminal scholarly literature, contemporary policy debates, and ongoing global economic disputes. The seminar functions as an active research incubator across the semester, with every component building toward an original piece of policy analysis.

Design Note: What This Course Is For

Every course I teach serves two objectives, and the assessment structure below is built to deliver them rather than to sample them.

One. Critical thinking, by crossing theory with real cases. Each week pairs a model with an empirical puzzle the model handles imperfectly, and the weekly Analytical Brief requires a position on that friction. A brief that summarizes the reading has not done the assignment. Students evaluate theoretical trade-offs, identify empirical vulnerabilities, or propose an alternative explanatory hypothesis.

Two. Policy orientation. I do not teach political economy as history. The capstone requires students to take a policy that is currently in force and work it through four analytical stages, described under the Final Research Paper below: establish what the policy was designed to do and why, identify who wins and who loses under it, assess its global effects and limits, and propose compensating mechanisms for the actors who bear its costs. That last stage is the one students find hardest, and it is the one that matters. Analysis that stops before it has to pay for itself is commentary.

This is also why the course is weighted toward cumulative writing and a defended capstone rather than examinations. Students hold a position under questioning from an audience that has read their draft.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- 1. Analyze how domestic societal interests and political institutions shape national trade, investment, and monetary policies amid competing pressures toward global economic integration and protectionism.
- 2. Evaluate the strategic mechanisms of modern economic statecraft, including supply chain management, weaponized interdependence, exchange-rate politics, and multilateral regimes.
- 3. Critique the political economy of development and international finance, evaluating how developing nations navigate industrialization strategies, sovereign debt crises, and global capital flow cycles.
- 4. Produce clear, concise, and analytically rigorous policy writing, culminating in an original research paper and an oral defense of a contemporary international political economy challenge.

Required Text

Thomas Oatley. *International Political Economy*, 7th Edition. New York: Routledge. [Abbreviated “Oatley” below]

Additional required articles and empirical readings are drawn from the peer-reviewed literature and are listed by week in the course outline. Students access them through the library’s subscriptions rather than through course-provided copies.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Seminar Participation	15%
Analytical Briefs (6 required)	25%
Individual Mid-Term Essay	20%
Final Research Paper and Oral Defense	25%
Draft Presentation and Peer-Review Session	15%
Total	100%

Formatting. All major written assignments are double-spaced and follow APA style. Stated lengths are strict maximum word limits. Bibliographies and references are excluded from the word limit. Graphs, charts, and tables are placed in appendices and do not count toward the body word limit.

Seminar Participation (15%)

Active participation is essential in a seminar. Students arrive having completed the assigned readings, prepared to dissect theories, evaluate case studies, and contribute to collective problem-solving. Attendance accounts for 5% of the final grade; the quality of contribution to discussion accounts for the remaining 10%.

Analytical Briefs (25%)

Students submit **six** analytical briefs of 250 to 300 words over the semester, drawn from seven opportunities, with the lowest score dropped. Each brief synthesizes the week's core concepts and responds to the analytical puzzle listed with that week in the course outline.

Critical perspective. Briefs must not summarize the readings. A successful brief evaluates the theoretical trade-offs at stake, identifies an empirical vulnerability in the argument, or proposes an alternative explanatory hypothesis. The standard is that the writer takes a position that a competent reader could contest, and defends it.

Individual Mid-Term Essay (20%)

A comprehensive theory-to-practice essay of no more than 1,300 words serves as the midterm assessment. The analytical prompt is distributed one week before the due date. The essay is evaluated on the precision of its theoretical application, the quality of its empirical support, and its handling of the strongest objection to its own argument.

Final Research Paper and Oral Defense (25%)

Students produce an individual capstone research paper of 2,000 to 2,500 words addressing a contemporary issue in international political economy. The paper incorporates rigorous theoretical modeling and draws on quantitative and empirical data from sources such as the World Bank, the IMF, the OECD, and the WTO.

Analytical core requirements. Every paper systematically addresses the following four elements, in order, from a strict global and international perspective.

1. **Origins of the policy challenge.** Define the contemporary challenge. Explain the underlying structural, economic, or political reasons that produced it, and analyze why new policies have been introduced in the current international context.
2. **Distributional consequences.** Evaluate the policy interventions by explicitly identifying the new winners and the new losers. Analyze how these policies shift the balance of power among state actors, domestic interest groups, and institutional architectures.
3. **Global implications and limitations.** Critically assess the potential global effects of the policy, identifying economic distortions, political resistance, retaliatory actions, or negative externalities.
4. **Compensatory mechanisms.** Propose targeted policy mechanisms to compensate the domestic or international actors who bear the costs of these shifts, with an eye to long-term political and economic stability.

Approved contemporary topics. Students select one of the following:

- **Tariffs and protectionism.** The tension between the domestic distributional costs of trade liberalization and global market efficiency, and contemporary debates on retaliatory tariffs and the fragmentation of the multilateral trade system.
- **Global supply chains and security.** The prioritization of national security and state control over market efficiency, and the political economy of supply chain resilience and geoeconomic vulnerability.
- **AI and the global labor market.** The impact of artificial intelligence and automation on global labor arbitrage, with attention to youth unemployment and structural adjustment in both developed and developing economies.
- **AI and the development gap.** Strategies for developing nations to navigate the artificial intelligence revolution: technology transfer, digital infrastructure, and the structural barriers to closing the global economic divide.
- **Cryptocurrency and digital finance.** The challenge of decentralized digital assets to state sovereignty, central bank monetary control, and the traditional global financial architecture.
- **Sensitive materials and strategic trade.** The geoeconomics of critical supply chains such as semiconductors and rare earth elements, and the use of export controls as economic statecraft.
- **Demographics and global capital.** The structural strain of declining birth rates and aging populations on national pension systems and taxation, and the consequent impact on global capital flows and sovereign debt.

Oral defense. Each student delivers a twenty-minute formal presentation of their research findings, followed by a fifteen-minute instructor-led and peer-led oral defense. Students are assessed on whether their argument survives questioning, and on whether they concede accurately when it does not.

Draft Presentation and Peer-Review Session (15%)

The seminar conducts a structured peer-review workshop. Each student brings physical copies of a complete rough draft to distribute to peers. This component is evaluated on the depth, precision, and constructive quality of the feedback a student provides to classmates. Students are being assessed on their capacity to improve someone else's argument, which is the same skill the oral defense will ask them to survive.

Course Policies

Use of Generative AI

AI tools may be used as research and search instruments: to explore a topic, identify relevant concepts, locate potential sources, or deepen understanding of unfamiliar material, provided that students independently verify the information and consult the original sources.

AI tools may not be used to produce, compose, rewrite, or paraphrase text for submission; to answer

questions assigned as coursework; to generate analyses or arguments; or to complete any portion of an assignment on a student's behalf. Students independently produce the written work they submit. The use of AI does not reduce a student's responsibility for the accuracy, originality, and proper attribution of their work.

Late Work

Work submitted without an acceptable excuse is penalized one full letter grade per day late, including non-business days. Work more than three days late without an approved excuse receives no credit. Where a documented circumstance prevents timely submission, students contact me within two business days of the deadline, preferably in advance, to arrange an extension or an alternative.

Communication

Announcements are posted weekly. Private administrative concerns go to institutional email; general course questions go to an open discussion board, so that classmates benefit from shared answers. Office hours are held weekly with both drop-in windows and scheduled individual appointments.

Course Outline

Readings are completed before the first meeting of the week. Chapters from the Oatley text are required; the additional articles listed each week provide foundational depth and analytical extensions. The analytical brief question listed with each week guides that week's submission.

MODULE 1: Foundations of International Trade and Multilateralism

This introductory module establishes the core theoretical frameworks of international political economy and examines the institutional architecture of global trade.

Week 1: Introduction to International Political Economy

Topics: What is IPE? Foundations of Open Economy Politics, and methodological approaches.

Readings: Oatley, Chapter 1.

No brief this week.

Week 2: The World Trade Organization and the World Trade System

Topics: The WTO, public goods, and the world trade system.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 2.

- Stiller, Kenneth T. 2024. “The WTO as Multilateral Diffusion Hub: Institutional Learning in WTO Disputes and the Design of Preferential Trade Agreements.” *International Studies Quarterly* 68(4).

Analytical Brief: Can the WTO survive without a hegemonic guarantor or an operational dispute settlement mechanism?

Week 3: The Political Economy of Trade Cooperation

Topics: Comparative advantage, trade bargaining, and enforcement dilemmas in trade agreements.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 3.
- Obstfeld, Maurice. 2021. “Globalization and Nationalism: Retrospect and Prospect.” *Contemporary Economic Policy* 39(4): 675–690.

Analytical Brief: Why is international trade cooperation so difficult to enforce in the absence of external enforcement authorities?

MODULE 2: Domestic Politics and State-Centered Trade Strategies

This module examines how domestic societal cleavages, factors versus sectors, and state-level strategic industrial policies shape national trade preferences and global economic outcomes.

Week 4: Society-Centered Approaches to Trade Politics

Topics: The factor and Stolper-Samuelson model against the sector and Ricardo-Viner model, collective action, and public trade preferences.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 4.
- Brühl, Volker. 2024. “The Economic Rise of China: An Analysis of China’s Growth Drivers.” *International Economics and Economic Policy* 22(1).

No brief this week.

Week 5: State-Centered Approaches

Topics: The infant-industry argument, strategic trade theory, green industrial policy, and strategic competition in semiconductors and AI.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 5.
- Juhász, Réka, and Nathan Lane. 2024. "The Political Economy of Industrial Policy." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 38(4): 27–54.

Analytical Brief: Does strategic trade policy improve social welfare, or does it produce inefficient protectionist rents?

MODULE 3: Trade, Development, and Structural Change

Analyzing the historical and contemporary economic strategies of developing nations, this module contrasts inward-looking structuralism with export-oriented growth models to understand the pathways to economic development.

Week 6: Import Substitution Industrialization

Topics: Structuralism, market imperfections, terms of trade, and the limits of inward-looking development.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 6.
- Bogliaccini, Juan A. 2019. "The Reconstruction of Business Interests after the ISI Collapse: Unpacking the Effect of Institutional Change in Chile and Uruguay." *Third World Quarterly* 40(7): 1378–1393.

Analytical Brief: Should developing countries move away from relying on comparative advantage and instead adopt import substitution industrialization?

Week 7: Neoliberalism and Institutional Reform

Topics: The East Asian model, structural adjustment, and export-oriented strategy.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 7.
- Wu, Qiujun, and Weichuang Fang. 2024. "The Middle-Income Trap and the Middle-Technology Trap in Latin America: A Practice Comparison Based on the East Asian Perspective." *Asian Review of Political Economy* 3(1).

Analytical Brief: What lessons does the East Asian development model offer for low-income countries navigating the middle-income trap?

Milestone: Mid-term essay prompt distributed.

MODULE 4: Multinational Corporations and Global Value Chains

This module investigates the drivers of foreign direct investment, the fragmentation of global value chains, and the regulatory tensions between sovereign states and transnational entities.

Week 8: Multinational Corporations in the Global Economy

Topics: FDI, locational advantages, market imperfections, global value chains, and the smile curve.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 8.
- Dünhaupt, Petra, and Hansjörg Herr. 2021. “Global Value Chains: A Ladder for Development?” *International Review of Applied Economics* 35(3–4): 456–474.

Milestone: Mid-term essay due.

Week 9: The Politics of Multinational Corporations

Topics: The obsolescing bargain model, regulating MNCs, investor-state dispute settlement, and the race to the bottom.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 9.
- Johns, Leslie, and Rachel L. Wellhausen. 2016. “Under One Roof: Supply Chains and the Protection of Foreign Investment.” *American Political Science Review* 110(1): 31–51.

No brief this week.

MODULE 5: The International Monetary and Financial Architecture

Exploring the evolution of the global monetary system, this module evaluates the politics of exchange rates, central bank independence, and the emerging challenges posed to state sovereignty by digital finance and cryptocurrencies.

Week 10: The International Monetary System

Topics: Exchange rate systems, the balance of payments, Bretton Woods, and the financial account.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 10.
- Sau, Lino. 2015. “Do the International Monetary and Financial Systems Need More than Short-Term Cosmetic Reforms?” *International Journal of Political Economy* 44(4): 325–340.

Analytical Brief: Why did the institutional design of the Bretton Woods system prove unsustainable, and to what extent have contemporary exchange-rate arrangements addressed the vulnerabilities that contributed to its collapse?

Week 11: Cooperation, Conflict, and Crisis in the International Monetary System

Topics: From the Plaza to the Louvre Accords, global imbalances, the 2007–2009 financial crisis, and exchange-rate cooperation in the EU.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 11.
- Hausken, Kjell, and Jonathan W. Welburn. 2022. “Assessing the 2010–2018 Financial Crisis in Greece, Portugal, Ireland, Spain, and Cyprus.” *Journal of Economic Studies* 49(1): 23–43.

Analytical Brief: Why is international exchange-rate cooperation so difficult to sustain in the face of global imbalances and domestic economic pressures?

MODULE 6: Domestic Monetary Politics, Global Finance, and Challenges to Globalization

The final module examines the domestic political drivers of monetary and exchange-rate policies, assesses the macroeconomic constraints on developing nations within global capital cycles, and evaluates contemporary challenges to the global capitalist economy, including populist pushback and great power competition.

Week 12: The Domestic Politics of Monetary and Exchange-Rate Policy

Topics: Society-based models and electoral and partisan politics.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 12.
- Gnangnon, Sèna Kimm. 2023. “The Real Exchange Rate and Services Export Diversification.” *Journal of Economic Studies* 50(6): 1105–1120.

Analytical Brief: Why do governments willingly surrender monetary policy autonomy to independent central banks or fixed exchange-rate regimes?

Week 13: A State-Centered Approach to Monetary and Exchange-Rate Policy

Topics: The time-consistency problem and central bank independence.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 13.
- Reinhart, Carmen M., and Kenneth S. Rogoff. 2011. “From Financial Crash to Debt Crisis.” *American Economic Review* 101(5): 1676–1706.

Milestone: Draft peer-review session. Rough drafts due in class.

Week 14: Achievements and Challenges to the Global Capitalist Economy

Topics: Globalization, the populist challenge to democracy, great power competition, sanctions, and weaponized interdependence.

Readings:

- Oatley, Chapter 16.
- Farrell, Henry, and Abraham L. Newman. 2019. “Weaponized Interdependence: How Global Economic Networks Shape State Coercion.” *International Security* 44(1): 42–79.

Analytical Brief: Will globalization survive the populist backlash and rising great power competition?

Milestone: Capstone oral defenses begin.

Week 15: Capstone Oral Defenses and Seminar Wrap-Up

Topics: Remaining individual capstone defenses and closing synthesis. **Milestone:** Capstone oral defenses conclude.

Final Research Papers due during the examination period.